

of the last half century is the progress of the frog out of his well.”

TALE SPINNER

Rooted in everyday life, his simple tragi-comedies set in the realistic small town world of the imaginary Malgudi were the first Indian stories to make a mark in English literature

■ By Anju Sahgal Gupta

Present day India boasts of a robust and diverse literature in the English language, and one of the greats who started it all was the fine storyteller Rasipuram Krishnaswami Narayan. Born in Madras in 1906, he was the third of eight surviving children and eldest brother to the famous cartoonist R.K. Laxman. Sent as an infant to live with his maternal grandmother and uncle until he was a teenager, he moved back to his parents when his father was appointed headmaster of Maharaja's High School in Mysore. Narayan was an indifferent student and after graduating from high school, he failed the college entrance examination in English because he found the textbook too boring to read. He took the examination again and eventually obtained his bachelor's degree from the University of Mysore.

He began his writing career in 1935 with *Swami and Friends*, where he created the imaginary small town of Malgudi, which was to be the backdrop for several succeeding novels, including *The Bachelor of Arts*, *The English Teacher*, *Mr Sampath*, *The Financial Expert*, *The Vendor of Sweets*, *The Painter of Signs* and *A Tiger for Malgudi*. An energetic, colourful albeit slightly eccentric place, it enabled Narayan to create wonderful characters and uncover simple universal truths.

After Narayan failed to find a publisher for *Swami and Friends*, the

draft was shown to Graham Greene, who liked it and arranged for its publication. Greene, like E.M. Forster and Somerset Maugham, was to become a close friend and admirer.

Following the realist tradition, Narayan's novels tell apparently simple tales of simple folk trying to live out their ordinary lives in a changing world where they struggle to accommodate tradition with modernity, often with tragi-comic consequences. His works are rooted in the everyday lives of Indians, giving his writing a certain unique flavour, as if he were writing in his native tongue. Autobiographical content also forms a significant part of some of his novels. The events surrounding the death of his wife from typhoid formed the basis of *The English Teacher*. At the same time, there is a certain cosmopolitan vision in his writing. Though immersed in the local, he observes his characters and their concerns dispassionately, almost like an outsider, often giving an ironic twist to his tales, as in *The Guide*.

What makes him so popular with the masses is his easy-to-read style, his unpretentious prose laced with wit, compassion and gentle humour. (He is also a great favourite of syllabus planners at both the school and college levels). However, it is this very quality of simplicity which has not found favour with some critics—Shashi Tharoor, for instance, while praising Narayan for his meticulous recording of the ironies of human life, feels that his apparent charm masked

the “banality of (his) concerns, the narrowness of his vision, the predictability of his prose, and the shallowness of (his) pool of experience.” Others liken him to William Faulkner and Anton Chekhov for his humour, compassionate insights and “celebration of simple folk”.

His stories and novels touched the core of the Indian heart and several of them were adapted as films and television serials. *Guide* was a huge commercial success, though Narayan himself was not happy with the screen adaptation. Many of us fondly remember *Malgudi Days*, a popular tele-adaptation of *Swami and Friends* and other stories by the late actor-director Shankar Nag.

Narayan won numerous honours for his works. He won the Sahitya Akademi Award for *The Guide* in 1958. In 1980, he was awarded the A.C. Benson Medal by the Royal Society of Literature. Narayan was elected honorary member of the American Academy and Institute of Arts and Letters in 1982 and awarded the Padma Vibhushan in 2000.

Narayan may not surprise us with great innovation or even great complexity and in that sense he certainly has not “charted new territory in his fiction”, but he has created characters we remember from our own lives and reminded us of the simple truths that we, more often than not, tend to forget.

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